

Healthy Living Guide

Your everyday blueprint for living longer and feeling better — practical, evidence-based habits for adults of every age.



NUTRITION



MOVEMENT



SLEEP & STRESS



PREVENTION

WHAT'S INSIDE

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"Small, consistent habits — not perfection — are what add years to your life and life to your years."

Dr. Jason Patera

Family Medicine · Nebraska Medicine

Based on guidance from USPSTF, AHA/ACC, ADA, ACSM, the American Cancer Society, CDC, and the Dietary Guidelines for Americans.

START HERE

The 10 Habits That Matter Most

You don't need to change everything at once. These ten habits have the strongest evidence for helping you live longer and feel better — pick one to start tomorrow.

- **1 Move every day**

150–300 minutes a week of moderate activity, plus strength training twice a week, lowers your risk of heart disease, diabetes, and early death.

Try this: take a 10-minute walk after dinner.
- **2 Eat mostly real food**

Build meals around vegetables, fruits, whole grains, lean protein, and healthy fats instead of packaged, ultra-processed foods.

Try this: choose foods with a short ingredient list.
- **3 Fill half your plate with produce**

Vegetables and fruit provide fiber, vitamins, and antioxidants that protect your heart, gut, and metabolism.

Try this: add a vegetable to two meals today.
- **4 Make protein a priority**

Protein helps preserve muscle, control appetite, and support healthy aging — at every stage of life.

Try this: include a protein source at every meal.
- **5 Choose water first**

Water supports nearly every process in your body and has zero calories or added sugar.

Try this: keep a water bottle where you'll see it.
- **6 Protect 7–9 hours of sleep**

Sleep restores your brain, balances hunger hormones, and supports a healthy weight and mood.

Try this: set a consistent bedtime, even on weekends.
- **7 Build strength & balance**

Strength training preserves muscle and bone as you age and lowers your risk of falls and injury.

Try this: start with two short sessions this week.
- **8 Nurture your mind & relationships**

Managing stress and staying socially connected are linked to a longer, healthier life.

Try this: reach out to one person you care about today.
- **9 Know your numbers**

Blood pressure, cholesterol, blood sugar, and weight trends are early warning signs your body gives you.

Try this: ask your care team what your numbers are.
- **10 Stay current on screenings & vaccines**

Preventive care catches problems early — when they are most treatable.

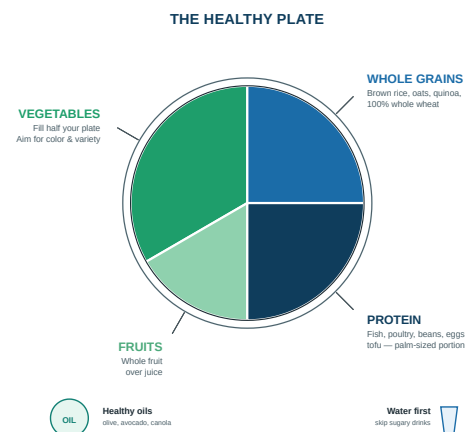
Try this: see page 9 for the schedule that fits your age.



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Eat Mostly Real Food

There is no single perfect diet — but a Mediterranean-style pattern, built mostly from whole foods, has the strongest evidence for a longer, healthier life.



Nutrient	Choose more often	Enjoy less often
Protein	Fish, poultry, eggs, beans, lentils, tofu, Greek yogurt	Bacon, sausage, deli & cured meats
Fiber	Vegetables, fruit, beans, oats, whole grains	Refined white bread & pastries
Fats	Olive oil, nuts, seeds, avocado, fatty fish	Fried foods, stick margarine
Carbohydrates	100% whole grains, legumes, starchy vegetables	Sugary cereal, refined snack foods
Added sugar	Whole fruit for something sweet	Soda, candy, sweetened coffee drinks
Processed foods	Home-prepared, minimally processed meals	Packaged snacks, fast food, sugary drinks

**DID YOU KNOW?**

Only about 5% of American adults eat enough fiber. Most need 25–38 grams a day.

**DID YOU KNOW?**

Large clinical trials show a Mediterranean eating pattern lowers the risk of heart attack and stroke.

**WHAT TO DO TOMORROW**

No food group is off-limits. Progress comes from what you add — more vegetables, more fiber, more protein — not from what you eliminate.

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Build Better Meals

A simple formula works for almost any meal: **protein + fiber + healthy fat + color.**



Breakfast

- ✓ Greek yogurt, berries & walnuts
- ✓ Eggs, whole-grain toast & avocado
- ✓ Oatmeal, peanut butter & banana
- ✓ Cottage cheese & fruit



Lunch & Dinner

- ✓ Palm-sized protein
- ✓ Half the plate vegetables
- ✓ Quarter plate whole grain or starchy veg
- ✓ A drizzle of olive oil



Meal Planning

- ✓ Plan 3–4 dinners before you shop
- ✓ Cook once, eat twice — make extra
- ✓ Keep a running grocery list
- ✓ Prep produce right after shopping

READ THE LABEL

Nutrition Facts	
8 servings per container	
Serving size	2/3 cup (55g)
Amount per serving	
Calories	230
% Daily Value*	
Total Fat 8g	10%
Saturated Fat 1g	5%
Trans Fat 0g	
Cholesterol 0mg	0%
Sodium 160mg	7%
Total Carbohydrate 37g	13%
Dietary Fiber 4g	14%
Total Sugars 12g	
Includes 10g Added Sugars	20%
Protein 3g	
Vitamin D 2mcg 10%	
Calcium 260mg 20%	
Iron 8mg 45%	
Potassium 240mg 6%	

Check the serving size first —
all numbers on the label are per serving.

% Daily Value shows how much
one serving contributes to a full day (based on 2,000 calories).

Fiber: aim for 25–38g a day —
look for 3g+ of fiber per serving.

Added sugars, sodium & saturated fat:
choose foods with lower % Daily Value more often.

Eating Out

- Look at the menu ahead of time and decide before you arrive
- Ask for dressing and sauce on the side
- Choose grilled, baked, or roasted over fried
- Start with a vegetable-based side or salad
- Box up half your meal before you start eating
- Choose water or unsweetened tea over soda



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Healthy Snacks

A good snack pairs protein or fiber with something you enjoy. Values are approximate and will vary by brand and portion.

Apple + 1 tbsp peanut butter

P 4g · F 4g · ~190 Cal

Fiber + protein keeps you full

Plain Greek yogurt (3/4 cup)

P 17g · F 0g · ~100 Cal

High protein, gut-healthy

Almonds (1 oz, ~23)

P 6g · F 3.5g · ~160 Cal

Healthy fats + fiber

Baby carrots + hummus (2 tbsp)

P 3g · F 4g · ~100 Cal

Crunchy fiber boost

Hard-boiled egg (1)

P 6g · F 0g · ~70 Cal

Portable protein

Cottage cheese + pineapple

P 12g · F 1g · ~120 Cal

Slow-digesting protein

Edamame, steamed (1 cup)

P 17g · F 8g · ~190 Cal

Plant protein + fiber

String cheese (1 stick)

P 7g · F 0g · ~80 Cal

Quick, portable protein

Trail mix, unsweetened (1/4 cup)

P 5g · F 2.5g · ~170 Cal

Energy + healthy fats

Banana + 1 tbsp almond butter

P 4g · F 4g · ~200 Cal

Potassium + protein

Whole-grain crackers + cheese

P 6g · F 2g · ~150 Cal

Balanced carb + protein

Roasted chickpeas (1/2 cup)

P 6g · F 5g · ~120 Cal

Crunchy plant fiber

Popcorn, air-popped (3 cups)

P 3g · F 3.5g · ~90 Cal

Whole grain, low calorie

Cherry tomatoes + mozzarella

P 7g · F 1g · ~110 Cal

Protein + produce

Protein smoothie (small)

P 20g · F 2g · ~150 Cal

Convenient post-activity fuel

Orange + 12 almonds

P 4g · F 5g · ~150 Cal

Vitamin C + healthy fat

Tuna (2 oz) + whole-grain crackers

P 12g · F 2g · ~140 Cal

Omega-3s + protein

Cucumber slices + tzatziki

P 3g · F 2g · ~90 Cal

Low-cal hydration + fiber

Overnight oats (1/2 cup)

P 6g · F 4g · ~150 Cal

Fiber-rich, make ahead

Dark chocolate square + walnuts

P 3g · F 2g · ~140 Cal

Satisfying, antioxidant-rich

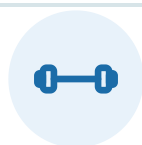
Protein (P) and fiber (F) in grams; calories (Cal) are approximate per listed portion.


DID YOU KNOW?

Pairing a carbohydrate with protein or fiber slows digestion, so blood sugar rises more gradually and you stay satisfied longer.


WHAT TO DO TOMORROW

Keep two or three of these on hand at home, at work, and in your bag so a healthy option is always within reach.

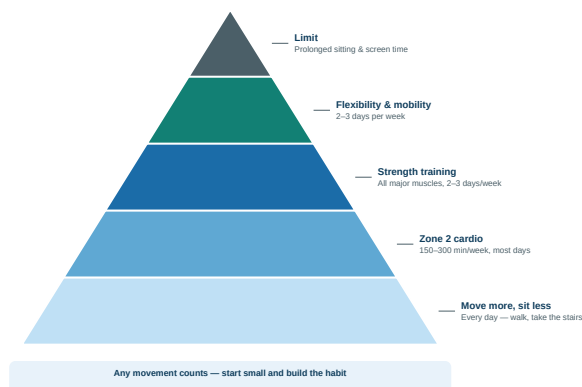


MOVEMENT

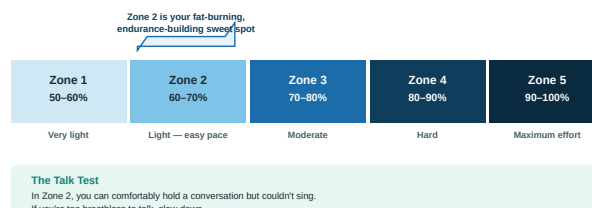
Exercise

Adults need 150–300 minutes of moderate aerobic activity a week, plus strength training at least twice a week. Any amount of movement is better than none.

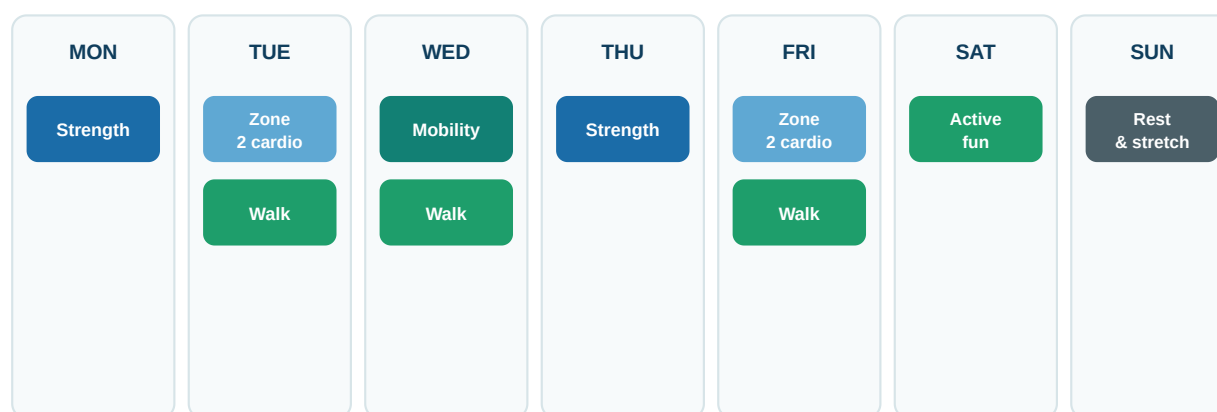
WEEKLY EXERCISE PYRAMID



UNDERSTANDING YOUR EXERCISE ZONES



A SAMPLE BALANCED WEEK



Any order works — the goal is consistency across the week, not perfection on any single day.

How to begin, at any fitness level

- ✓ Start with 10 minutes of walking, most days
- ✓ Add 2 short strength sessions a week
- ✓ Use the talk test to find your Zone 2 pace
- ✓ Add 5 minutes of mobility work after warming up
- ✓ Increase time or distance by about 10% a week
- ✓ Choose an activity you actually enjoy — it will last longer



MOVEMENT & NUTRITION

Healthy Weight

**DID YOU KNOW?**

Losing just 5–10% of body weight can improve blood pressure, blood sugar, fatty liver disease, and joint pain.



Timing & Fasting

What you eat matters more than exactly when you eat. Intermittent fasting can be a helpful tool for some people to manage calorie intake, but it isn't required and isn't right for everyone — including those who are pregnant, have a history of an eating disorder, or take medications for diabetes. Ask your care team first.



GLP-1 Medications

GLP-1 medications can be an effective option for some adults with obesity or type 2 diabetes. They work best alongside — not instead of — healthy eating, strength training, and sleep, which help preserve muscle while losing weight. Talk with your care team about whether one is right for you.



Behavior Change That Lasts

- ✓ Change one habit at a time
- ✓ Track progress with more than the scale — energy, sleep, and clothes fit all count
- ✓ Protect your sleep — poor sleep increases hunger hormones
- ✓ Manage stress — it drives cravings and emotional eating

SUSTAINABLE HABITS FOR A HEALTHY WEIGHT

**PROTECT YOUR MUSCLE**

Whether or not you use medication, pairing weight loss with adequate protein and regular strength training helps preserve muscle and keep your metabolism strong.



WELL-BEING

Sleep, Stress & Connection

Most adults need 7–9 hours of sleep a night. Sleep, stress, and relationships all shape your physical health.



Sleep Hygiene

- ✓ Keep a consistent sleep & wake time
- ✓ Keep your room cool, dark & quiet
- ✓ Limit screens for 30+ minutes before bed
- ✓ Avoid caffeine after early afternoon
- ✓ Get morning sunlight when you can



Managing Stress

- ✓ Try slow breathing for 2 minutes
- ✓ Take a short walk outside
- ✓ Write down what's on your mind
- ✓ Limit news & social media before bed
- ✓ Notice tension without judging it



Social Connection

- ✓ Reach out to one person most days
- ✓ Say yes to shared meals & activities
- ✓ Join a group tied to an interest
- ✓ Ask for help — and offer it



DID YOU KNOW?

The U.S. Surgeon General has identified loneliness and social isolation as risk factors for heart disease, stroke, and dementia — comparable in impact to other well-known health risks.



WHEN TO REACH OUT FOR HELP

If low mood, anxiety, or stress are affecting your daily life for more than two weeks, talk with your care team. Effective treatment is available, and asking for help is a sign of strength, not weakness.



A 2-Minute Reset for a Stressful Moment



1. Pause

Stop what you're doing and sit or stand comfortably.



2. Breathe

Inhale for 4 counts, hold for 4, exhale slowly for 6. Repeat 5 times.



3. Reset

Name one thing you can do next — then take that one small step.



PREVENTION

Preventive Health

Screenings and vaccines catch problems early. Ask your care team which of these apply to you.

Screening	Who	How often
Blood pressure	All adults	Every visit; at least annually
Cholesterol	Adults 20+	Every 4–6 years, more often with risk factors
Blood sugar / diabetes	Adults 35–70 who are overweight, or with other risk factors	Every 3 years
Breast cancer (mammogram)	Women 40–74	Every 2 years
Cervical cancer	Women 21–65	Every 3–5 years (Pap/HPV)
Colorectal cancer	Adults 45–75	Colonoscopy every 10 yrs, or annual stool test
Lung cancer (low-dose CT)	Adults 50–80 with a significant smoking history	Annually
Dental exam & cleaning	All adults	Every 6–12 months
Vision exam	All adults	Every 1–2 years, more often after age 60
Hearing check	All adults	Baseline, then as needed
Skin check	All adults, especially with risk factors	Annually, or if a mole changes



Vaccines

- **Influenza** — every year
- **Tdap/Td** — once, then booster every 10 years
- **Shingles** — age 50+
- **Pneumococcal** — age 65+, or earlier with certain conditions
- **COVID-19** — per current CDC guidance



SUN & SKIN PROTECTION

Use SPF 30+ daily, seek shade midday, and check your skin monthly for new or changing spots — remember the ABCDEs: Asymmetry, Border, Color, Diameter, Evolving.



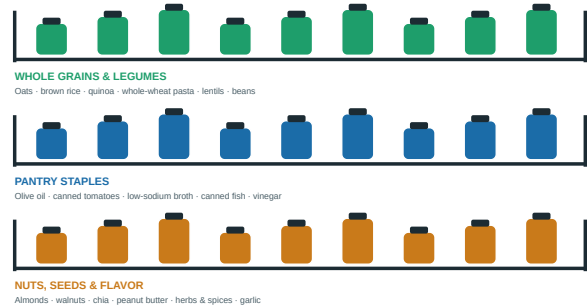
NUTRITION

Healthy Grocery Guide

SHOP THE HEALTHY CART



STOCK A HEALTHY PANTRY



Simple Swaps

Instead of	Choose more often
White bread	100% whole-grain or whole-wheat bread
Sugary breakfast cereal	Oats or a lower-sugar, whole-grain cereal
Soda or sweetened tea	Sparkling water or unsweetened tea
Potato chips	Air-popped popcorn or nuts
Regular pasta	Whole-wheat or legume-based pasta
Creamy salad dressing	Olive oil & vinegar
Frozen meals, highly processed	Plain frozen vegetables & proteins you season yourself

YOUR QUESTIONS



Frequently Asked Questions

- **Is fruit too sugary?**

No. The fiber in whole fruit slows sugar absorption. Whole fruit is linked to better, not worse, health outcomes.
- **Are eggs bad for cholesterol?**

For most people, eggs in moderation (about one a day) fit well into a healthy eating pattern.
- **Is coffee healthy?**

Moderate coffee (3–4 cups/day) is linked to neutral or lower risk of several conditions. Watch the added sugar and cream.
- **Are artificial sweeteners safe?**

FDA-approved sweeteners are generally safe in moderation and can help reduce added sugar. Water is still the best default.
- **Do I need protein shakes?**

Not necessarily. They're a convenient option if you struggle to get enough protein from food — choose a lower-sugar option.
- **How much alcohol is safe?**

Less is better. If you drink, current guidance suggests limiting to 2 drinks/day or fewer for men and 1 or fewer for women.
- **Do I have to eat breakfast?**

Not necessarily — it depends on the person. If you do eat breakfast, prioritize protein and fiber to help you feel full.
- **Do I need a multivitamin?**

Most nutrients are best absorbed from food. Some people benefit from specific supplements (like vitamin D) — ask your care team.
- **Does intermittent fasting work?**

It can help some people manage calorie intake, but it isn't more effective than other approaches when calories are matched, and isn't right for everyone.

**STILL HAVE QUESTIONS?**

Bring this guide to your next visit. Your care team can help you turn any of these habits into a plan that fits your life.

EVIDENCE BASIS

References & Guidelines

This guide reflects current guidance from major medical and public health organizations. It is educational and does not replace personalized medical advice from your care team.

Nutrition

- U.S. Dietary Guidelines for Americans, 2020–2025
- American Heart Association dietary guidance
- PREDIMED & related Mediterranean diet trials

Exercise

- American College of Sports Medicine (ACSM) guidelines
- Physical Activity Guidelines for Americans, HHS

Weight & Diabetes

- American Diabetes Association (ADA) Standards of Care
- AHA/ACC/Obesity Society guidance

Cancer Screening

- American Cancer Society screening guidelines
- U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF)

Cardiovascular Health

- American Heart Association / American College of Cardiology (AHA/ACC)

Sleep & Mental Health

- American Academy of Sleep Medicine
- U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on Loneliness (2023)

General Prevention

- Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC)
- U.S. Preventive Services Task Force (USPSTF)

About the Author

Dr. Jason Patera is a family medicine physician with Nebraska Medicine. This guide is part of a series of patient education booklets designed to help patients build sustainable, evidence-based habits for lifelong health.

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COMING NEXT IN THE NEBRASKA MEDICINE HEALTH SERIES

Look for future guides on heart health, diabetes prevention, and healthy aging.